

The Way That Cannot Be Spoken: An Introduction to Daoism

An original lesson plan inspired by **Chad Hansen's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Daoism. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Chad Hansen. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/daoism/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Eastern Philosophy

“The opening line of the Daodejing declares that 'the Dao that can be spoken is not the eternal Dao' — what would it mean to build a philosophy around truths that resist being captured in words, and how could such a philosophy even be taught?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the concept of Dao and why classical Daoist texts insist that fixed language and naming distort or fail to fully capture it.
- Define wu-wei ('non-action' or effortless action) and ziran (naturalness/spontaneity), distinguishing both from mere passivity or laziness.
- Apply Daoist ideas to evaluate a modern case of striving versus effortless action, constructing an argument about what wu-wei would actually recommend doing.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt handout with the opening lines of Daodejing chapter 1 (on the unnameable Dao) and the water metaphor from chapter 8 or 78
- Wu-wei case cards describing modern scenarios (an athlete 'in the flow,' a manager who micromanages every detail, a student who over-prepares for a conversation)
- Whiteboard for a two-column chart contrasting striving/forcing against wu-wei

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Describe the Indescribable

8 min

Ask students to try to describe, in words, what a color looks like to someone who has never seen it, or what it feels like to ride a bike to someone who has never balanced on one. Use their struggle to introduce the idea that some things resist full verbal description even though we clearly still know them. This previews the Daodejing's opening claim about the Dao and language.

Direct Instruction: The Dao and the Limits of Naming

15 min

Read and discuss the opening lines of Daodejing chapter 1: the Dao that can be spoken or named is not the eternal, constant Dao. Explain that classical Daoist texts treat fixed naming and rigid categories as inherently limiting — carving up a fluid, ever-changing reality into static labels distorts it, even though naming is unavoidably useful for everyday life. Contrast this suspicion of fixed language with the Confucian emphasis (which students may know from elsewhere) on correctly naming roles and duties.

Direct Instruction: Wu-Wei and Ziran

17 min

Introduce wu-wei, often translated 'non-action,' clarifying that it does not mean literal inactivity but rather acting without forcing, striving, or imposing artificial effort against the natural grain of a situation. Read the water metaphor: water is the softest thing, yet nothing overcomes the hard and strong better than it does, precisely because it yields and follows the shape of what it meets rather than fighting it directly. Connect wu-wei to ziran, naturalness or spontaneity — acting in a way that flows from a thing's own nature rather than from external imposition.

Small-Group Case Application

13 min

In small groups, students take one wu-wei case card and analyze it: is the person in the scenario acting with wu-wei/ziran, or against it? What would a more wu-wei-aligned approach to their situation look like concretely? Groups record their answer on the board's two-column chart under 'forcing' or 'flowing.'

Closure

7 min

Reconvene and ask a few groups to share their case. Return to the essential question: does building a philosophy around what resists being spoken actually work as a philosophy, or does Daoism undercut its own project the moment it starts writing books about the Dao? Take final reactions.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If the Dao that can be named isn't the real, eternal Dao, isn't the Daodejing itself, being made of words, automatically failing to capture what it's about? How might a Daoist respond to this worry?
- 2 Is wu-wei realistically achievable in a modern life full of deadlines, or does 'effortless action' only make sense for very specific, low-stakes situations?
- 3 The water metaphor suggests that softness ultimately overcomes hardness — can you think of a real situation, personal or historical, where yielding actually was a more effective strategy than direct force?

- 4 Does Daoism's suspicion of naming and categorizing conflict with the very act of teaching Daoism using specific terms like 'wu-wei' and 'ziran'? Is this a contradiction, or something Daoist texts anticipate and accept?
- 5 How is wu-wei different from simply giving up or being lazy? What specifically distinguishes 'effortless action attuned to a situation' from just not trying?

Assessment

Students write a short response applying wu-wei to a real challenge in their own life (a difficult conversation, a skill they're learning, a conflict with a friend), describing specifically what a 'forcing' approach to the situation would look like versus a wu-wei-aligned approach, and evaluating which seems more likely to actually work.

Extension Activity

Have students observe someone skilled at an activity (a musician, an athlete, a cook) and write a short analysis of whether that person's skilled performance looks more like wu-wei (natural, unforced fluency) or like visible effort and strain, and what that suggests about the relationship between practice and effortlessness.

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